

Some months before, after he had downed a few pegs, he had put his arm around my shoulder and said: 'You are my true friend, Lala . . . if anybody ever tries to fuck around with you, just let me know. I shall fix him.'

'How? By getting him beaten up?' I had asked.

'No, that will only inflict momentary pain. I have something more lasting. I know people who will have that fellow photographed nude alongside some whores; after that he will be at your mercy forever,' he said, laughing. It was a sinister laugh and made my stomach churn a little. I was not sure if he meant what he had said but I could not dismiss his claim outright. After all, he was known to be well connected to the high and mighty in the market.

Sitting with him now, I suspected that Lucky may have a similar plan for me. He was a friend all right, but a pretty ruthless person, as I had realized in these months that I got to know him better.

'Let's leave and go to some other place,' I told Lucky.

'So soon? We have just come,' he said.

I persisted.

He was amused. 'Okay . . . but let's have some fun before that,' he said.

I shifted in my seat uneasily.

He then gave me a rundown on some of the girls on the floor.

'That one in pink there, she is the favourite of a respected businessman who has trouble getting his thing up. His fondness is for money more than women. But somebody introduced him to that girl, and since then he is a regular in this place,' Lucky said, winking ' . . . but I am not going to reveal who that businessman is.'

I didn't even want to know. All I wanted was to get out of that place.

Sensing my indifference, Lucky then said: 'I shall show you somebody who will just blow you over,' and beckoned to a very attractive girl, who would not have been more than twenty-two or twenty-three.

'Payal, I want you to meet my friend Lala,' Lucky said.

'Hello,' she greeted me with a warm smile. I could sense that this girl had some class about her; she was definitely not the run-of-the-mill type.

'Our friend is a bit shy, why don't you liven him up a bit,' Lucky told her.

'Sure,' saying which she moved to the dance floor and began swaying to the number that was playing. I tried hard not to look in her direction, but when I stole a glance I saw that she was casting seductive glances at me.